

“Imaginary Barbarians”: Nationalism, Orientalism, and the Establishment of Alterity in late Eighteenth to mid Nineteenth-Century Russia

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Abstract

The publication of Afanasyi Prokopievich Shchapov’s “The Russian Schism of the Old Believers” in 1858 elicited a positive reception among the Russian Empire’s leading intellectual figures. Sergey Mikhaylovich Solovyov, the leading proponent of the “state school” of history, was particularly impressed by the unassuming thirty-year-old half-Buryat from Siberia, and as a result of this recognition, Shchapov was awarded the post of a history professor at the University of Kazan¹. [1] His very first lecture, however, entailed a formal denunciation of his former protector’s “Great Russian historiography”, accusing Solovyov of writing a “biography of tsars and princes” while erasing the common people². Not only was this indictment met with enthusiastic approval, as evinced by the generous applause following the conclusion of his lecture, but it also set the foundations for a deconstructivist approach to empire. Although Shchapov’s fixation on organic regional development has frequently been dismissed as petty bourgeois by later Soviet authorities or ignored altogether, his writings prompted a historiosophic re-evaluation of the colonial self and the other, revealing an important development in the Russian intelligentsia’s attitude regarding its position within a multi-ethnic empire. My paper will elucidate the trajectory of the Russian Empire’s attempt at constructing an imperial identity through state-sponsored education for its agents, with centralization and an increased borderland presence prompting the need for a unified identity amongst the empire’s administrators and bureaucrats. This paper will argue that Russian portrayals of “the other” were based on mercantile notions of one’s service to the state while simultaneously positing Russian Imperial identity as an alternative to the Eurocentric East-West binary.

On the eve of the Great Reforms, imperial Russian society was divided into multiple legal estates, creating a plethora of social identities crafted along ethnic, corporate, and religious lines. These categories, however, were not mutually exclusive, and one’s social status was primarily dictated by estate rather than ethnicity. Reinforcing cleavages did exist, although the Empire’s highly diverse

¹ Georgii Gloveli, “Afanasiĭ Shchapov— Istorik rossiĭskoiĭ tsivilizatsii.” *Federalizm*, no. 2 (2011), 171.

² Afanasiy Prokopievich Shchapov, “Obshchiĭ vzgliad na istoriiu velikorusskogo Naroda” in *Neizdannye sochinenia* (Kazan: Tip. “Vostok” izd-va “Gazhur”, 1926).

population created a complex hierarchy. The state's insistence on maintaining separate spheres contrasted significantly with Western Europe's political understanding of romantic nationalism; while Western states were busy building their "imagined communities" on the idea of a unified nation, the Russian Empire continued to enforce corporate identities. It was only after the Great Reforms of the 1860s that the government proceeded to promote a national model of self-identification along Western lines.³ With the Empire's promotion to a major European power in the eighteenth century, Russian imperial statesmen were increasingly forced to confront the exigencies of modernity and its political and economic consequences, with questions pertaining to centralization, political participation, nationalism, and self-determination becoming matters of state security. While the ever-expanding Empire had little problem absorbing new territories, ineffective administration encumbered by chronic shortages of human capital posed significant problems regarding the governance of far-flung peripheries and their peoples.

Catherine II's age of conquest and enlightenment inaugurated an era of state-sponsored jingoist historiography and education, as Pugachev's rebellion and Polish resistance to the Commonwealth's partitioning revealed potentially lethal cracks in the Empire's foundations. The threat of emerging nationalism paired with increasingly destructive peasant uprisings impelled Petersburg to co-opt local elites into the administrative apparatus, placing state allegiance and servitude as the foundation of Russian imperial identity. This emphasis on centralization, whether real or imagined, became the basis for court-sanctioned historical narratives, as government-sponsored education aimed to inculcate a self-identification with the state. Using a comparative framework, this paper will examine varying methodological approaches proposed by Russian historians from the late eighteenth to mid-nineteenth centuries in conceptualizing the non-Russian "other". By leading with the counterexample of the federalist historian Afanasiy Shchapov, this paper will aim to demonstrate how Russian historical narratives were continuously constructed against the threat of imperial disintegration and revolution, elucidating how centralization and an increased borderland presence prompted the need for a unified identity among imperial administrators and bureaucrats.

The Empire's carefully crafted historical narrative was shattered with the University of Kazan's decision to hire Afanasiy Prokopievich Shchapov in 1860. The half-Buryat history professor was immediately placed under government scrutiny following his inaugural lecture wherein he condemned the imperial trend of promulgating "Great Russian historiography", counter-proposing a decentralized methodology that he termed *oblastnichestvo*, roughly translating to "regionalism".⁴ Given that the term "regionalism" may sound mundane to the anglophone reader, a brief etymological overview of the original Russian word for region (*oblast*) is necessary, as the English translation is stripped of its original political and historical connotations. Whereas the customary usage of the term "region" usually denotes a generic territorial unit which may be defined along linguistic, geographic, ethnic, or other similar features, the term *oblast* was used to delineate a specific administrative unit in Imperial Russia. While *oblastii* existed in Kievan times, and the word has been used as a synonym for region, its usage as an administrative term fell out of practice until imperial administrative reforms. Although these were quite frequent, starting with Peter I's massive reorganization of the Empire into governorates (*gubernii*), provinces (*provintsii*), and districts (*distrikty*), it is important to note that

³ Paul Werth, "Changing Conceptions of Difference, Assimilation, and Faith in the Volga-Kama Region, 1740–1870," in *Russian Empire: Space, People, Power, 1700–1930*, ed. Jane Burbank, Mark von Hagen, and Anatolyi Remnev (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2007), 170.

⁴ Afanasiy Prokopievich Shchapov, "Obshchii vzgliad na istoriiu velikorusskogo Naroda," in *Neizdannye sochinenia* (Kazan: Tip. "Vostok" izd-va "Gazhur", 1926) 12.

oblastii, a direct subdivision of the governorates, were located primarily in the borderland regions.⁵ It goes without saying that these peripheries were populated by non-Russian minorities, and given the quasi-military governance of these territories, the term *oblast* had distinct colonial connotations.

Although the use of *oblastii* as a form of subdivision became more popular at the turn of the eighteenth century, with some governorates (*namestnichestva*) in European Russia being subdivided into *oblastii*, the term was nonetheless primarily associated with the Empire's more-recently acquired territories.⁶ In his aborted constitution proposed to Alexander I, Mikhail Speransky was very explicit in his division of region-specific administration, all with the goal of subjugating the Empire's territories to better suit "the disposition of state forces."⁷ In order to achieve this, Speransky proposed the following:

- I. The Russian Empire is divided into regions (*oblastii*) and provinces (*gubernii*).
- II. The naming of regions (*oblastii*) is accorded to those parts of the empire which, due to their space and population cannot be included in the general order of government. These regions (*oblastii*) are: 1) Siberia, up to the Ural mountains; 2) the Caucasian region (*krai*) with Astrakhan and Georgia; 3) the Orenburg region (*krai*); 4) the land of the Don Cossacks; 5) the region (*krai*) of Novorossiysk.⁸

Shchapov's use of the term *oblastnichestvo* was thus etymologically charged, expressing what was essentially an anti-colonial discourse in Aesopian language. The historian's radical ideas regarding regionalism, local democracy, and anti-statism were therefore relatively short-lived, particularly given his arrest and resettlement following his public condemnation of the Bezdna massacre in 1861. Nonetheless, Shchapov's lectures and writings helped formulate an interpretive framework which allowed his followers to reimagine their identity as crafted against, rather than by the state.⁹

Shchapov's historiographical interpretations and later political manifestations have been interpreted as part of a broader federalist turn in Russian political philosophy which originated with the Decembrists and lasted until the rise of Marxism. Despite being one of several historians interested in a more decentralized approach to empire, Shchapov's unique ideological contribution to the revolutionary and reform movements of the 1860s cannot be understated, particularly when considered against the background of state involvement and frequent intervention in education dating back to Peter I.¹⁰

⁵ See George V. Lantzeff's *Siberia in the Nineteenth Century: A Study of the Colonial Administration* (Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1943) for a comprehensive overview of Muscovy's approach to developing colonial institutions aimed at regulating and exploiting its newly conquered territories.

⁶ Marc Raeff, *Michael Speransky: Statesman of Imperial Russia, 1772–1839* (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1969), 151.

⁷ Mikhail Mikhailovich Speransky, "Vvedenie k ulozheniiu gosudarstvennykh zakonov," in *Plan gosudarstvennogo preobrazvaniia grafa M.M.Speranskogo: Vvedenie k ulozheniiu gosudarstvennykh zakonov 1809 g. s prilozheniem* (Moskva: Russkaia mysl', 1905), 71.

⁸ *Ibid.*, 71–72.

⁹ One of the Siberian *oblastniki*'s main grievances was the fact that Siberia did not have its own university, forcing its most prominent youth to study in European Russia, particularly St. Petersburg. This resulted in the creation of Siberian student circles known as *zemliachestva* which devoted themselves to the study of their native Siberia. This was bolstered by Shchapov's transfer to the capital from Kazan in 1861 following his criticism of the Bezdna massacre. For a detailed analysis of Shchapov's involvement in these student groups see Dimitri von Mohrenschildt, "The 'Federal School' of Historiography: N. I. Kostomarov and A. P. Shchapov," in *Toward a United States of Russia: Plans and Projects of Federal Reconstruction of Russia in the Nineteenth Century* (East Brunswick: Associated University Presses, 1981).

¹⁰ In *The Revolution of Peter the Great* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2003), James Cracraft maintains that amongst all of Peter's numerous reforms, it was the cultural revolution that had the strongest impact. Cracraft further argues that Peter successfully struck a balance between Europeanizing the state yet maintaining a Russian identity.

Despite the lapse in personal ideological intervention during what has essentially been viewed as a sort of interregnum between Peter I and Catherine II, the growth of educational institutions prevailed. A more centralized and personal approach was adapted during Catherine II's reign, as Petersburg decided to better assert its place under the sun vis-à-vis its Western rivals. Nikolai Karamzin was thus crowned the father of Russian history, with his *History of the Russian State* setting the historiographical precedent for *gosudarstvennost'*, roughly translating to "allegiance to the state" and promoting a state school of history which justified and celebrated the autocracy as a primary historical force.¹¹ Although he had been derided by liberal critics for his subservience to the Tsar, with Pushkin famously clowning the *History's* "grace [and] simplicity which [proved] the need for autocracy and the charm of the whip,"¹² Karamzin set an important precedent regarding state-centric metanarratives that would continue to spark debate throughout the remainder of the imperial period all the way up to the revolutions.

Obsequiousness aside, it is Karamzin's approach to empire that deserves special attention, particularly given that it promulgated a government-sanctioned perception of itself. Western-style education and state building went hand in hand, resulting in the Empire's early historians becoming the government's servitors. The foreword to Karamzin's monumental *History* encapsulates this position, positing the Russian Empire against a carefully crafted Western historical foil.

Aside from the personal dignity they afford us, Russia's sons, [Russia's] chronicles offer [something universal]. Let us look at the space of this entire, singular State: thoughts freeze; even Rome in its greatness could never rival her, having ruled from the Tiber to the Caucasus, from the Elbe to the African sands. Isn't it wonderful, how lands separated by eternal natural barriers, immeasurable deserts and impenetrable forests, freezing and scalding climates, such as Astrakhan and Lapland, Siberia and Bessarabia, were capable of forming a single State with Moscow? Is her mixture of inhabitants less wonderful, multiethnic, diverse, or distant in terms of education?¹³

For Karamzin, the answer to this hypothetical question was a resounding "no" of course, as the historian ardently believed the Third Rome easily trumped its predecessors' achievements. It is also important to note the conspicuous absence of comparison with contemporaneous empires. For Karamzin, the conquest of pre-trodden ground south of the Terek river and west of the Urals did not constitute geopolitical prowess; it was the eastern orientation, which had hitherto been inaccessible due to climatic limitations, that served as the marker of distinction and superiority.¹⁴ The conquest of nature and its subjugation to rationalist forces had been a distinct feature of the Enlightenment, and Karamzin's ties to the eighteenth century went deeper than the mere promulgation of reason.

¹¹ In "The Political Ideas of Russian Historians" *The Historical Journal* 27, no. 3 (1984) David Saunders argues that the Russian nineteenth century has been dominated by three historiographical schools: *gosudarstvennost'*, *narodnost'*, and *partiinnost'*, thus delineating their adherents as advocates for either the state, the people, or the party, respectively. According to Saunders, the two primary adversaries, statist and populists, did not disappear with the advent of organized labour, but rather continued to resurface throughout the twentieth century. Nonetheless, Saunders acknowledges that the general periodization of trends follows the order he initially listed.

¹² Aleksandr Sergeevich Pushkin, "Na Karamzina," *Sobranie sochinenii v 10 tomakh* (Moskva: GIKHL, 1959), 1:66.

¹³ Nikolai Mikhailovich Karamzin, "Predslovie," in *Istoriia gosudarstva Rossiiskogo* (Sanktpeterburg: v tipografii N. Grecha, 1818), 1:12.

¹⁴ David Moon is the first historian to properly address the environmental impact of Russia's colonization of the steppe lands. His seminal *The Plough that Broke the Steppes: Agriculture and Environment on Russia's Grasslands, 1700-1914* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013) demonstrates that despite the initial bountiful yields of this new found 'bread basket', the long term effects of intensive agriculture had severe environmental consequences. In a closer case study, "Agriculture and the environment on the steppes in the nineteenth century," in *Peopling the Russian Periphery: Borderland Colonization in Eurasian History*, ed. Nicholas B. Breyfogle, Abby Schrader, and William Sunderland (New York: Routledge, 2007), Moon elucidates that by the nineteenth century, Russian academics were split on the issue of agricultural sustainability in the steppe lands, with one school of thought arguing for the necessity of human intervention in nature, whereas the second argued that long-term consequences were inevitable.

Although he was viewed as the father of Russian historiography, Karamzin was partially indebted to Vasily Tatishchev, an eighteenth-century statesman who paved the way for future scholars and provided an important blueprint regarding Russia's transitory position between East and West.

Although he never completed his *Russian History from the most Ancient Times*, Tatishchev's oeuvre foreshadowed the general direction of Imperial methodology. Given his premature death, Tatishchev's *History* ends with Ivan IV's reign, although some sketches of the Time of Troubles remain. Empire building plays an important role, naturally, although it his approach to expansion, particularly eastward, that deserves special attention. Although Tatishchev's scholarly rigour has been placed under scrutiny, with some modern historians claiming he fabricated an entire chronicle, Tatishchev's methodological dedication to written primary sources, whether alleged or real, was consistent enough.¹⁵ Furthermore, he was equally persistent in questioning foreign scholars, although his critique aimed to highlight the asymmetrical discourse promulgated by contemporaneous historians and thus consciously posited Russian historiography against the Western foil:

All European writers, including historians and geographers, [refer to the entirety of Asia] as Great Tartary, but it is not certain from where this name originates; the ancients never used it, and Ptolemy only mentioned the Mogul people... In the [European] historical Lexicon, the name "Tatar" denotes numerous peoples who do not belong to this group. Indeed, this mistake is found amongst all European writers, who include Sarmatians..., Tanguts, Mongols, etc. under this [umbrella] term.¹⁶

Although Russian historians had initially based their scholarship on European standards, they remained aware of the West's condescending attitude towards Russian culture and education.¹⁷ Tatishchev was therefore understandably smug in his derision of European historians, although his focus on the Russian East was more than an inversion of a power complex. Russia's Muscovite past was elevated, with its geopolitical orientation placing the future Empire at a unique cultural crossroads. Later Westernizers viewed this as a civilizational shortcoming, encapsulated by Petr Chaadaev's claim that Russians "do not belong to any of the great families of the human race, [being] neither of the West nor of the East, and [having] the traditions of neither."¹⁸ This sentiment, however, was not universally shared among the Empire's statesmen and intellectuals, leading to an active debate regarding the nature of empire and its cultural orientation. The East–West dichotomy has become an ideological Shibboleth for historians with the publication of Edward Said's *Orientalism* in 1978, although Said's critique has only recently affected Western and Russian scholarly debate.¹⁹ In

¹⁵ In "Modern Russian Historiography" *The Journal of Modern History* 9, no. 2 (1937), Anatole G. Mazour argues that despite professional Russian historiography originating in the nineteenth century, Tatishchev's contributions cannot be diminished particularly when contextualized against the problematization of pre-existing scholarship. Mazour demonstrates that the influence of medieval relics and Polish chronicles severely handicapped the development of native scholarship, and the production of countless forgeries that had accumulated during the appanage period constituted one of the most academically debilitating obstacles. Tatishchev's lapses ought to thus be evaluated against this problematic background, with his contributions and dedication to scholarly rigour exceeding the flaws which arose from the exigencies of the times.

¹⁶ Vasily Tatishchev, "Glava vosemnadtsaia: Ostatki Skifov, Turki, i Tatar," in *Istoriia Rossiiskaia s "samykh" drevnēshikh vremen" neuspnyimi trudami cherez" tritsat' lēt" sobrannaia i opisannaia pokoīnym taīnym sovetnikom i astrakhanskim gubernatorom, Vasil'em Nikitichem Tatishchevym* (Moskva: Imperatorskii Moskovskii Universitet, 1843), 1:275.

¹⁷ Larry Wolff's *Inventing Eastern Europe: The Map of Civilization on the Mind of the Enlightenment* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1994) explores the origins of Europe's self-conceptual shift from a South–North to an East–West cultural divide, arguing that Western Europe's Enlightenment philosophers built the idea of a backwards Eastern Europe as a means of constructing an alterity that would elevate Western Europe's alleged civilizational superiority.

¹⁸ Petr Chaadaev in Nicholas V. Riasanovsky and Mark D. Steinberg, *A History of Russia*, 9th ed. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2019), 309.

¹⁹ David Schimmelpenninck van der Oye's "The Curious Fate of Edward Said in Russia," in *L'orientalisme des marges: Eclairages à partir de L'Inde et de la Russie*, ed. Philippe Bornet and Svetlana Gorshenina (Lausanne: Université de Lausanne, 2014) argues that until the 1980s, both sides of the Iron Curtain argued against studying Russia as a colonial space akin to the West; it was the collapse of the Soviet Union that prompted a fresh form of analysis. The most famous debate

addition to viewing Russia as a colonizing space, recent historians have turned toward the notion of Russia as a colonized space.²⁰

Ironically, this line of historical inquiry which appears to be the result of a post-modern and decolonial approach was debated at great length by nineteenth-century Russian historians, with the East-West issue transcending Slavophile-Westernizer debates. It is clear, however, that Russian imperial identity developed as much against the West as it did the East, with historians taking up Tatishchev's mantle and further promulgating Russia's place outside of what became the normative European-Oriental binary. The conservative journalist and historian Mikhail Pogodin was decidedly caustic in his evaluation of European interpretive frameworks, claiming that "Western writers don't have an appropriate understanding of Slavic nations. Finding the foreign language completely unsurmountable, [the French, English, and Germans], laden with prejudice, don't expect to learn anything interesting from the imaginary barbarians..."²¹ Pogodin's auto-designation of the Russian self as an "imaginary barbarian" encapsulates and pre-dates Said's criticism of the constructed Orient or East in the European imagination, simultaneously placing Russia outside the Western sphere yet reliant on its position as one of several foils.

Alterity had to therefore be constructed both alongside and against Europe, and given the cultural and ethnic ambiguities of the Empire's understanding of nationality, territory initially served as the least problematic designator of difference. Furthermore, the idea of "geographical determinism" promulgated by nineteenth-century scholars found a particular form of expression in Russia, wherein its native intellectuals postulated the theory that nature in Western Europe was nurturing, whereas in Russia it was debilitating and thus had to be conquered.²²

The delineation of alterity thus depended on the construction of an ideological justification for the state's expansion, significantly affecting imperial self-perceptions and outward projections of empire. Pre-Petrine conceptions regarding territorial sovereignty differed greatly from Enlightenment notions of state rationalization, although it was not until the nineteenth century that the problem of demarcating a core and periphery started plaguing Russian scholars and intellectuals.²³ Aside from the perennial issue of defining boundaries surrounding "central" (*tsentral'naia*), "native" (*korennaiia*), or "interior" (*vnutrenniaia*) Russia, scholars were additionally troubled by the recognition of a single epicentre to serve as the core.

In an age increasingly defined by the Moscow–St. Petersburg polarity, the historian and ethnographer Vadim Passek accepted the idea of cultural plurality, positing the theory of multiple centres represented by three historical national nodes: Moscow, Novgorod, and Kiev.²⁴ Although the relationship between these three cities was obviously asymmetrical, particularly upon entering the age of the railway which bypassed Novgorod entirely, it nonetheless helped establish the idea of separate

regarding Said's applicability to the Russian colonial experience took place in *Kritika: Explorations in Russian and Eurasian History* 1, no. 4 (2000) between Nathaniel Knight and Adeeb Khalid. The latter had championed a Saidian approach, arguing that nationalist approaches had led to an exceptionalist treatment of Russian expansion, whereas the former claimed that Khalid's "universalist" approach was in fact an acceptance of established hegemonic models treating the traditional West as normative. This paper leans towards Knight's approach, arguing that the Western, capitalist, over-seas model has eclipsed alternative forms of analysis.

²⁰ Alexander Etkind's *Internal Colonization: Russia's Imperial Experience* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2011) offers a seminal approach to the notion of Russia as empire. Etkind argues that Russia's colonization was simultaneously external and internal, with the latter being the result of the state's exploitation and gradual enserfment of its peasant population.

²¹ Mikhail Petrovich Pogodin, "Istoricheskie razmyshleniia. Ob otnoshenii Pol'shi k Rossii", *Teleskop*, no. 7 (1831): 295.

²² Moon, "Agriculture and the Environment on the Steppes in the Nineteenth Century", 87.

²³ According to Leonid Gorizontov, "The 'Great Circle' of Interior Russia: Representations of the Imperial Center in the Nineteenth and Early Twentieth Centuries," in *Russian Empire*, ed. Burbank et al., the main impetus for this sudden intellectual interest was the War of 1812; symbolic and strategic significance blended with Napoleon's occupation of Moscow resulting in a plethora of historical, economic, and ethnographic considerations.

²⁴ Gorizontov, "The 'Great Circle' of Interior Russia", 71.

yet not necessarily mutually exclusive cultural spheres of influence which served to shape one's identity. Furthermore, it is interesting to note that these spheres rarely coincided with physical delineators such as rivers or mountains. Passek's own memoirs, wherein he recounts his first sojourn to Moscow from his native Siberia, provide a telling critique of the perceived Europe–Asia dichotomy:

Here we stopped, took one more look at Siberia. The sun was rising on this side; we took a look at the west and started to descend the other side of the Urals. From this height it seemed as though I saw both boundaryless halves of Russia— with her people and their fates! Soon I was surprised by tribes I'd never seen before: we had arrived amongst the Votiaks. Their villages are located in dark forests, almost all are next to rivers and in comfortable places...²⁵

The notable absence of “Europeanness” west of the Urals, particularly in the first half of the nineteenth century, demonstrates that despite the many administrative and political reforms of the age of Enlightenment, autocracy remained the only steadfast pillar of Nikolai I's imperial ideology of Official Nationalism.²⁶

Nonetheless, Nikolai I's proclamation of the doctrine of Official Nationalism deserves closer scrutiny given its newfound fixation on nationality as a core feature of the government's ideology. It is important to note that scholars have viewed the feature of nationality as a reciprocal extension of autocracy wherein “nationality” is defined by the Imperial subjects' devotion and submission to the tsar rather than as an expression of Western Romantic nationalism. What deserves to be further analyzed, however, is how this was reflected in the state's promulgation of public education and the burgeoning intellectual and public spheres.

It was upon receiving the post of the Ministry of Education, or rather more literally, the Ministry of National Enlightenment, that Count Uvarov publicly proclaimed his doctrine of Official Nationality for the first time. In an official speech addressed to the heads of Educational Districts, Uvarov asserted his dedication to promoting king and country in education, concluding that:

Our common obligation is based on the principal that national education, in accordance with the intentions of the most August Monarch, be committed to the unified spirit of Orthodoxy, Autocracy, and nationality. I am convinced that every one of our Professors and Teachers, having absorbed the very feeling of dedication to the Throne and Fatherland, will use all their strength to become a worthy weapon of Orthodoxy and to deserve its full trust...²⁷

These were not the empty formalities of a minister accepting a comfortable sinecure, however, but a public addressing of the government's concerns regarding the growing local autonomy of the various educational institutions, both higher and elementary, that had been set up by Alexander I. This was partially prompted by the renegade western provinces and exacerbated by the perennial Polish problem which had recently flared up in the November Uprising. The government proceeded to

²⁵ Vadim V. Passek, *Putevye zapiski* (Moscow, Tipografiia Semena Selivanovskago, 1834), 11.

²⁶ Nicholas Riasanovsky's *Nicholas I and Official Nationality in Russia, 1825–1855* (Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1969) provides a comprehensive overview of the Russian government's ideological and political orientation under Nicholas I's reign. In addition to providing a comparative analysis of Nicholas' centralizing efforts as a normative model akin to other modernizing European states such as Louis XIV's France, Riasanovsky argues that despite the introduction of “radical nationalism” as a way to supersede the old dynastic order, Russia's attempt at shifting away from a feudal orientation did not succeed, and thus the empire remained entrenched in its pre-modern self-perceptions until 1917. Nonetheless, the fundamental principles defining Uvarov's idea of nationality rested on the notion of absolute devotion and submission to the tsar, shaping a distorted notion of citizenship defined as an acceptance of autocracy rather than civic participation.

²⁷ Uvarov, “Tsirkuliarnoe predlozhenie Glavnogo Upravlieniushchego Ministerstvom Narodnogo Prosveshcheniia Nachal'stvam Uchebnym Okrugov, o vstuplenii v upravlenie Ministerstvom,” (21 marta, 1833), in *Zhurnal Ministerstva narodnogo prosveshcheniia* (Sanktpeterburg: Tipografiia Imperatorskoï Akademii Nauk, 1834), 1:il-l.

announce a competition incentivized by a hefty prize for the best history textbook that would adequately deal with the question of statehood and empire. Given the political rigors of the times, even the conservative Pogodin was turned down in favour of the Ministry's new reactionary darling, Nikolai Ustryalov.²⁸ It was his *Outline of Russian History*, the first volume of which was completed in 1846, that became the official secondary school textbook and won the prestigious Demidov prize for adequately elucidating the western peripheries' place within the empire.

Although forced to acknowledge the inadvertent feudalization of territory during the appanage period, Ustryalov utilized this as an opportunity to decry what he saw as the bifurcation of the Kievan patrimony. He thus presented an Eastern and Western Rus' as two parts of an organic whole that had been artificially partitioned by the joint efforts of a Polish-Lithuanian and Tatar cabal. The western borderlands' struggle against the Commonwealth was presented in the same light as Muscovy's struggle against the Golden Horde, wherein "just like the eastern [Rus'] saved its faith, its language, its customary practices... the nation, having sacredly protected the laws of its forefathers [yearned] to [re]become the Orthodox Tsar's subjects..."²⁹ The theme of unifying the Poles and Tatars as Rus' ancient enemies is commonplace throughout the entire monograph, although it is interesting to note that Ustryalov presented the two as equal in their civilizational capacity as an existential threat without hinting at a European-Asiatic differentiation.³⁰ It is ironic that the specter of a unified Polish-Tatar threat would re-emerge some four centuries later in Siberia, further highlighting the vagrancies of Russian approach to empire.

Natural boundaries remained at the forefront of Ustryalov's political thought, and he considered Catherine II's annexations as the fulfillment of the Empire's organic expansion, carefully crafting Russia's identity against the backdrop of European aggression. Ustryalov considered Catherine to serve as the ultimate ruler who:

...completed the thought of ancient tsars and the numerous plans of Peters: under her rule she united almost all of the Russian land, including a significant portion of the Polish kingdom; gifted her country a decisive advantage over neighbouring nations... Having assimilated the best fruits of European civic-mindedness without, however, its harmful weeds, thus differing by maintaining its national character, its boundless devotion to faith and throne, Russia was unshakeable amongst the instability of Western countries...³¹

It was thus with Ustryalov that the official party line was fully entrenched, situating the Empire comfortably between East and West. As was expected, any timid attempts at counteracting the official narrative were ruthlessly crushed.

Nonetheless, the 1830s witnessed the first stillborn attempt at decentralizing the historical narrative, with journalist and historian Nikolai Polevoi cautiously proposing a non-statist approach when analyzing the Empire's development.³² As expected, he was ruthlessly put down, and while scholarly debate was virtually muzzled until the mid-century, Polevoi's ideas outlived his detractors, making his works worth analyzing. The publicist and historian was particularly active a year before

²⁸ For a comprehensive overview of the Ministry's commissioning of a state-sanctioned monograph and the ensuing responses and backlash see David B. Saunders' "Historians and Concepts of Nationality in Early Nineteenth-Century Russia", *The Slavonic and East European Review* 60, no. 1 (1982).

²⁹ Nikolai Gerasimovich Ustryalov, *Nachertanie russkoï istorii, dlia srednikh uchebnykh zavedenii* (Sankt-Peterburg: Tipografiia Shtaba voenno-uchebnykh zavedenii, 1842), vii.

³⁰ *Ibid.*, 61–92.

³¹ *Ibid.*, ix.

³² In "The Political Ideas of Russian Historians" Saunders considers Polevoi as one of the failed "proto-populists", identifying Nikolai Chernyshevsky and Vasilii Semevskii as the successful proponents of *narodnost'* or "allegiance to the people at large" whose works influenced the subsequent course of Russian historiography. Both historians were mainly active in the second half of the nineteenth century.

the November Uprising of 1830, simultaneously publishing a restrained yet critical review of Karamzin's *History*, all the while issuing the first tome of his own historical cycle. Following several paragraphs of panegyrics regarding Karamzin's contribution to the cultural and intellectual development of Russian society, Polevoi hesitantly suggested that Karamzin was a relic of the eighteenth century, and despite completing his magnum opus in the nineteenth, he remained rooted in a pre-national, pre-Romantic past, essentially being "a writer, philosopher, and a historian of the past century, of the previous generation, and not of ours."³³ This was accompanied by the publication of his own history, which was pointedly titled *History of the Russian People* as a counterweight to Karamzin's *History of the Russian State*, dangerously suggesting a shift in the notion of the origins of sovereignty.

Although disagreeing with Pogodin's state-centric narrative, favouring a Hegelian narrative instead, Polevoi maintained a similar attitude towards Russia's position along the East-West axis. His approach to primary sources corroborates Pogodin's views vis-à-vis Westerners, claiming that given the difficulty of mastering not just Russian but its ancient permutations such as Old Church Slavonic, the Westerner would never grasp the Russian spirit, asserting that "a Frenchman will sooner understand an Englishman than [Russians], who have their own ritual of formation different from all of Europe, their own faith, their Euro-Asiatic mores and customs."³⁴

Irrespective of their stance vis-à-vis Europe, the almost simultaneous publication of Polevoi's two works was met with a furor, with the aforementioned Pogodin publishing an acerbic review himself wherein he derided Polevoi's history as full of "self-praise, insolence, ignorance, charlatanism in the highest and most disgusting degree, turgid and senseless phrases...excerpts from Karamzin translated into barbaric language...not a single new thought, neither true nor false, not a single historical explanation..."³⁵ Needless to summarize, it was not a positive reception, although it is important to note that this intensity of vitriol was not unique, but rather exemplary of the derision reserved for those straying from the state line. It is within this context that Shchapov took up the crucible of regionalism, and although his career was launched following Nikolai I's death, similar attitudes of state-subservience remained, making any alternative attempts virtually seditious.

The government under Nikolai I did more than simply commission monographs; despite its restrictive and arguably counter-reformative measures regarding education, the government needed an executive system through which students could be inculcated, making education a primary vehicle of indoctrination. Primary and secondary schools received extra funding, infrastructure was developed, and academic standards and quality were rigorously enforced. Higher education did not escape notice either, despite being an alleged "den of wolves".³⁶ Despite placing the establishment of new universities on hold, even closing the Polish university in Vilnius for obvious reasons, Nikolai's government opened numerous institutes of higher learning, frequently focusing on technical education, and also expanded universities by creating new faculties and departments.³⁷ Nikolai's approach to schooling thus ought to be viewed as a form of cameralism in education, demonstrating the need to establish a hegemonic narrative that would ultimately serve the state's interests.

³³ Nikolai Alekseevich Polevoi, "Istoriia gosudarstva Rossiiskogo. Sochinenie Karamzina," *Moskovskii Telegraf* (Moscow), June 1829, pt. 27, no. 12, 472.

³⁴ Nikolai Alekseevich Polevoi, *Istoriia Russkago Naroda* (Moskva: v tipografii Avgusta Semena, pri Imperaterskoï Mediko-Khirurgicheskoi Akademii, 1829), 1:xl.

³⁵ Mikhail Petrovich Pogodin, "Russkie knigi. Istoriia Russkogo naroda. Soch. N. Polevogo. Tom I. 1829," *Moskovskii Vestnik*, (Moscow), 1830, no. 1, 165.

³⁶ Nikolai I was famously suspicious of the Empire's universities and their influence on students' revolutionary potential. A well-known anecdote recalls the Tsar passing the Moscow University in his carriage, ominously pointing out to his companion that therein lay a wolves' den. See Riasanovsky and Steinberg, *Russian History*, 311.

³⁷ Riasanovsky and Steinberg, *Russian History*, 312.

As one of the oldest universities in the Empire, founded in 1804 by Alexander I, the University of Kazan was Russia's easternmost university until the end of the nineteenth century. It thus acted as the leading centre of Asian studies, although the Empire's turn towards Eastern subjects dated back to Peter I who established Oriental studies as one of the key academic disciplines within the Russian Academy of Sciences.³⁸ Despite the brief yet draconian rule of Mikhail Magnitskii who curtailed faculty and imposed restrictive measures towards the end of Alexander's reign, the University of Kazan developed substantially under Nikolai's auspices, being viewed as an important cultural-political node and further developing its focus on Orientology.³⁹ Moreover, the University of Kazan became a focal point of interest upon Uvarov's accession to the post of Minister of Education.

Within a single year of Uvarov's appointment, several important reforms had been enacted in order to better accommodate its increased importance. As a reflection of its growing relevance, the university was accorded a substantial sum of nearly half a million rubles for the construction of new buildings and infrastructure in order to accommodate the needs of its students.⁴⁰ In addition to the clear financial incentive, the ministry made further changes to its philology department, clearly promulgating policies and goals that had been in place since Peter I. Interest in the East prevailed, and the Ministry was unambiguous in its instructions: "Having found out that the combined study of Mongolian and Tatar languages results in important outcomes, the Minister of Education [suggested to the Kazan Educational district] that students learning one of the languages additionally begin the study of the other language."⁴¹ It is important to note, however, that the impressive scholarly rigour was largely prompted by practical considerations, with the Russian Turkic population playing a significant role in the Empire.

Kazan's importance as a key centre of education therefore cannot be understated, particularly when compared to the Empire's education policies regarding the western provinces. Ustryalov's ascent to fame was brought about as a prophylactic response to the western provinces' ambiguous role within the Empire, and it is fitting that the most pertinent and influential critique of the state's interpretation of nationality stemmed from the western provinces. The writings of Polish historians Joachim Lelewel and Zorian Chodakowski highlighted the discrepancy and separate development of Slavic cultures, with Chodakowski paying special attention to Ukrainian and Ruthenian histories.⁴² Although the polemics they exchanged also predominantly took place in the earlier part of Nikolai's reign, they nonetheless set the stage for the Ukrainian turn in the Empire's historiography, although it is the manner in which nationalism intersected with regionalism and federalism that reflects the heterogeneity of political thought vis-à-vis empire amongst the Empire's intellectuals.⁴³

Nikolai Kostomarov, one of the most prominent figures in Ukraine's mid-nineteenth-century cultural revival, was one of the pioneering advocates of a decentralized approach to Russian historiography, although his focus was primarily "ethnic-federative" as compared to Shchapov's

³⁸ David Schimmelpenninck van der Oye, *Russian Orientalism: Asia in the Russian Mind from Peter the Great to the Emigration* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2010), 33.

³⁹ *Ibid.*, 100.

⁴⁰ See "Ob upotreblenii 391.575 r. 94 1/4 k. dlīa postroiki novykh zdaniī Kazanskogo Universiteta," x, and "Ob upotreblenii 12.982 r. 81 k. dlīa postroeniia podvizhnoi bashni na Observatorii Kazanskogo Universiteta," xxii, in *Zhurnal Ministerstva narodnogo prosveshcheniia*, vol. 1.

⁴¹ "O sovokupnom izuchenii Mongol'skogo i Tatarskogo iazykov v Kazanskom Universitete," (Marta 29), in *Zhurnal Ministerstva narodnogo prosveshcheniia*, 2:cviii.

⁴² Saunders, "Historians and Concepts of Nationality," 49.

⁴³ Saunders postulates that in the nineteenth century, Russian historians initially championed statism only to shift towards populism towards the second half of the century, whereas Mohrenschildt views populism through a regionalist lens, arguing that the exigencies of empire forced Russian political thought to compartmentalize space, thus developing spatial conceptions in tandem with the needs of its peoples.

“federative-regional” approach.⁴⁴ Kostomarov’s writing served as a manifestation of the European nationalist interpretations creeping into Russian political philosophy; his seminal article explicitly titled “Two Russian Peoples” argued that while nationalities could be formed at varying stages of history, organic development rooted in a deep historical past grants more legitimacy, resulting in Ukraine professing greater historical credentials given its lengthy tradition of federative principals in politics. Ukraine’s distinctiveness is thus emphasized along the principle of historical legitimacy, with the author emphatically claiming that Southern Rus’ existed as a distinct entity, albeit as an early prototype, since antiquity.⁴⁵

Despite his focus on the national element, Kostomarov’s conception of modern nationhood was not defined in purely ethnic terms, but rather focused on notions of proto-democracy and citizenship. Kostomarov admitted that identities are malleable and shaped by socio-political events throughout history, and although he did claim that a culturally distinct “proto-Ukrainian” people existed since antiquity, he was also quite explicit in affirming that their national character had changed since as a direct result of the political systems espoused by its neighbours, Muscovy and the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth. The resulting establishment of the Zaporozhian Host was thus a defining moment according to Kostomarov, who considered the Cossacks the torchbearers of Ukrainian culture since the Mongol occupation. Although his focus had always remained Slavdom, it is interesting to note that Kostomarov acknowledged and even underlined the Tatar influence, which in his eyes, constituted an important element that did not diminish the ethnic validity of Ukrainianness.

Moreover, Kostomarov posited Ukrainian diversity and Muscovite centralization as a nation-defining dichotomy which bifurcated following the Mongol invasion. Kostomarov drew parallels between the Zaporozhian Cossacks and the *druzhyny* of Kievan Rus’, highlighting the latter’s diverse composition, all the while claiming that the modern iteration “[was] also heterogeneous, like the ancient Kievan *druzhyny*; it additionally incorporated an ethnic admixture of Turkic elements, it was also ruled by a personal arbitrariness, [it was] the same striving towards a goal...”⁴⁶ It is important to note that while Kostomarov was undoubtedly a proponent of a national approach to history, his conception of a modern Ukrainian *volksgeist* was nonetheless rooted in an ethnically heterogeneous corporate identity, as demonstrated by first the *druzhyny* and subsequently by Cossackdom.

The crackdown on the Brotherhood of Saints Cyril and Methodius resulted in the shutdown of Ukrainian intellectual activities, although this did not preclude the continued development of Ukrainian identity and nationally-oriented intellectuals.⁴⁷ While Kostomarov’s example demonstrates that while nationalist approaches existed, they were not the default critical lens for anti-statist historians, making the question of regionalism particularly poignant.

The unabated continuation of the empire-building project necessitated the introduction of a standardized approach in governing its far-flung territories, and with the introduction of new territorial forms of organization came a novel classification of the empire’s inhabitants. It is one of the main arguments of this paper that this was not a Westernizing approach in the sense that it aimed to posit the self against the colonial other, but rather an extension of the normative Muscovite practice to pragmatically reorganize to better govern difference within the heterogenous state. The closest the

⁴⁴ Mohrenschildt, *Toward a United States of Russia*, 78.

⁴⁵ Nikolai Ivanovich Kostomarov, “Dve Russkie narodnosti,” *Osnova* (Petersburg), 1863, no. 3, 33–40.

⁴⁶ *Ibid.*

⁴⁷ For an in-depth analysis of Kostomarov’s influence and the subsequent fate of the Ukrainian national revival in the nineteenth century, see Thomas Prymak’s “Mykola Kostomarov and East Slavic Ethnography in the Nineteenth Century,” *Russian History* 18, no. 2 (1991).

Empire had thus gotten to creating a legally-specific category of “other” was the introduction of Speransky’s “Statute on the *Inorodtsy*” in 1822 which created a legal category known as *inorodets* for non-Slavs living east of the Urals to better regulate the payments of *yasak*, or fur tribute. This, however, had less to do with categorizing the “other” in a religious or ethno-linguistic sense, but was rather a part of the government’s efforts in centralizing state revenue and further building on the estate system. The historiographical debate surrounding the term *inorodets* underscores the disparity between the legal and vernacular understandings of the signifier’s application.⁴⁸ Although the state’s legal designation did not always coincide with ethnicity or even its own education policies, it remained consistent in its systematic broadening of the application in tandem with its own construction of a centralized bureaucracy and state apparatus.

To summarize, Russia undertook a massive reorganization of empire between the early eighteenth to mid-nineteenth centuries. New conquests and continued territorial expansion resulted in significant administrative reforms, while the exigencies of a modern bureaucratic apparatus prompted the state to increasingly focus on culture and education. The Enlightenment under Catherine II inaugurated the birth of Russian historiography, and considering the Empire’s expansionist foreign policy at the time, an apologist narrative was enforced, defending imperial conquest and celebrating the state. This trend was amplified in the first half of the nineteenth century, as the expansion of educational institutions coincided with Petersburg’s need for a loyal servitor class that would self-identify with the state. Dissident attempts at decentralizing “Great Russian Historiography” were ruthlessly put down, either by informal public pillorying or outright state intervention and arrest. Nonetheless, both regionalist and statist historians took pride in Russia’s geopolitical orientation, arguing that its position between East and West established the Empire as a unique polity naturally superior to Europe. Statesmen and intellectuals thus established an alternative to the East-West binary, hoping to challenge the European-dominated age of modernity and colonialism. Russian Imperial identity was thus crafted against the West as much as it was posited against the East, with Pogodin’s “imagined barbarians” encapsulating the genesis of this foundational axiom.

⁴⁸ John W. Slocum’s “Who, and When, Were the *Inorodtsy*? The Evolution of the Category of “Aliens” in Imperial Russia” *The Russian Review* no. 2 (1998) provides a historical overview of the term *inorodets*, arguing that its initial use as a legal designator classifying Siberia’s native population gave way to a pejorative informal use meant to other non-Russians. Andrei A. Znamenski’s “The ‘ethic of empire’ on the Siberian borderland: the peculiar case of the ‘rock people,’ 1791–1878,” in *Peopling the Russian Periphery: Borderland Colonization in Eurasian History*, ed. Breyfogle et al. offers a unique perspective regarding the *inorodets* debate. His chapter explores the fate of “the rock people”, a group of dissenting Old Believers who were re-admitted into the state’s apparatus, although they were given *inorodets* legal status and paid tribute. Both works explore the relationship between ethnicity and legal status, demonstrating that the two were not mutually exclusive prompting identities to frequently overlap.

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